PC **Philosophy Commons**

INSPIRED LESSON PLAN

Beyond Lucky Guesses: Gettier and the Search for a Definition of Knowledge

*An original lesson plan inspired by **Jonathan Jenkins Ichikawa & Matthias Steup**'s the Stanford Encyclopedia of Philosophy entry on The Analysis of Knowledge. Not affiliated with or endorsed by Stanford Encyclopedia of Philosophy or Jonathan Jenkins Ichikawa & Matthias Steup. Explore the original course: https://plato.stanford.edu/entries/knowledge-analysis/*

GRADE LEVEL	DURATION	TOPICS
Grades 11-12 / Intro College	60 minutes	Epistemology

> *"We usually assume knowledge is just justified true belief — so why did a three-page paper by Edmund Gettier convince most philosophers that this definition is wrong?"*

Learning Objectives

By the end of this lesson, students will be able to:

- Explain the traditional justified-true-belief (JTB) analysis of knowledge and reconstruct a classic Gettier case that satisfies JTB without seeming to be knowledge.
- Apply the "no false lemmas" condition and a reliabilist condition to the Gettier cases to test whether either patch successfully blocks the counterexample.
- Evaluate whether knowledge can be given tidy necessary-and-sufficient conditions at all, and defend a position using an original example.

Materials Needed

- Handout with the JTB definition and two classic Gettier cases (the "stopped clock" and the "Ford/Barcelona" job-candidate case) in accessible language
- Whiteboard for building and testing candidate definitions
- Small dry-erase boards or paper for groups to draft their own new Gettier case
- Sticky notes for a gallery walk of proposed fixes

Lesson Procedure

Hook: Lucky Guesses vs. Knowledge

7 min

Present a simple case: you glance at a clock reading 3:00, believe it's 3:00, and it happens to actually be 3:00 — but unbeknownst to you, the clock stopped exactly twelve hours ago. Ask whether you knew it was 3:00, or just had a lucky true belief, and poll the room.

Direct Instruction: JTB and the Gettier Problem — 15 min

Present the traditional analysis — S knows that p if and only if p is true, S believes that p, and S is justified in believing that p — then formally present Edmund Gettier's 1963 counterexample structure: cases where a belief is justified and true, but only true by luck, due to reasoning from a justified-but-false premise. Walk through the "Ford/Barcelona" case, where a person validly infers a disjunction that happens to be true for a completely unrelated reason, to show a JTB belief that is intuitively not knowledge.

Small-Group Activity: Patch or Break It — 20 min

Assign each group a proposed solution: the "no false lemmas" condition (knowledge requires that no step in your justifying reasoning be false), a causal/reliabilist condition (knowledge requires the belief being produced by a reliable process appropriately connected to the fact), or the task of devising a brand-new Gettier-style case designed to defeat both proposed fixes. Groups test their assigned fix against the stopped-clock and Ford/Barcelona cases and try to construct a scenario that still slips through.

Whole-Class Share-Out — 13 min

Groups present their test cases and new Gettier-style scenarios. Discuss whether the recurring pattern of "always another counterexample" suggests something structurally wrong with the whole JTB-plus-patch approach.

Closure — 5 min

Exit ticket: in one sentence, is knowledge analyzable into simpler component conditions, or is it a more basic, unanalyzable notion?

Discussion Questions

1. In the stopped-clock case, what exactly is missing that would turn the lucky true belief into genuine knowledge?
2. Does the "no false lemmas" condition succeed in ruling out the Ford/Barcelona case, or can you construct a Gettier-style case where every step of reasoning is true and justified, yet the belief still seems beaten by luck?
3. Is justification the right third condition to add to true belief, or should we replace it with something else entirely — reliability, safety, or sensitivity to the truth?
4. Why do Gettier cases all seem to share a common structure — a justified true belief reached "by accident" through a chain involving luck — and does noticing that structure suggest a fix, or does every proposed fix generate its own new counterexample?
5. Is the whole project of finding necessary and sufficient conditions for knowledge worth pursuing, or should epistemologists treat "knowledge" as a primitive concept that resists this kind of tidy analysis?

Assessment

Students construct their own original Gettier-style case, not one discussed in class, that satisfies the JTB definition without seeming to be genuine knowledge, and then test it against the "no false lemmas" and reliabilist fixes discussed in class, explaining whether either fix blocks their case. Grade on whether the constructed case genuinely fits the Gettier structure and on the rigor of the fix-testing.

Extension Activity

Have students research one additional proposed solution to the Gettier problem not covered in class — such as the safety condition, the sensitivity condition, or virtue epistemology's "credit for true belief" approach — and write a short summary of how it attempts to handle the classic cases.